January 1974. My daughter, Urvashi (also called Sonia), was born in Delhi just before we moved to Wellington.

The Defence Services Staff Course was an enriching experience as for the first time, I had an exposure to a tri-service and an all arms and services environment. Besides, one got to meet and interact with some of the brightest brains of our armed forces as also those from friendly foreign countries. We were taught how to analyse a problem in a logical and pragmatic manner and to express it succinctly in writing or orally. The art of problem-solving in a focused way and in a compressed time frame was something that has remained with me ever since. Being one of the juniormost and among the first few in my batch on the course, I was fairly disadvantaged as I had no 'previous course knowledge', famously known as PCK. Many senior guys on the course were well-armed in this regard. They played golf or partied after submitting their solutions in good time, whereas I would be tearing my hair and struggling to finish my work till the last minute, with the directing staff breathing down my neck. There was a lot of sporting activity as well as a hectic social life at Wellington. It was one of the best periods of my life. We actually practised the maxim 'work hard and play hard'. We made some lifelong friends and this association has stood me in good stead all my life.

The year in the Staff College passed very quickly. Before we knew it we were packing our bags. Rohini and the kids moved to Delhi and I to New Mal, a godforsaken little non-family station in the Dooars of North Bengal, as the brigade major (BM) of 123 Mountain Brigade. Our formation had the task to defend our border in the eastern theatre. When the postings were out, a lot of my friends pulled my leg saying, 'JJ, it's good you are going as BM to "Stiffy" Vadehra. He will sort you out, nice and proper.' Brigadier P.S. Vadehra had a reputation of being a hard taskmaster, a thorough professional and a fitness freak. He was a soldier who had a vice-like handshake.

When I reported to him, he sized me up and his first remark was, 'Where did you get these fancy shoes from?'